



AN HONEST FIELD GUIDE 2026

What Saudi Arabia Is Really Paying Mining Talent in 2026

Salaries, packages, lifestyle and the career case — an honest guide for mining professionals in Australia, South Africa, Canada and Chile.

Real salary bands inside · SAR + USD · the full package, decoded

THE OPPORTUNITY

Every serious name in mining is heading to Saudi

Mature mining markets are managing decline. Saudi Arabia is building an industry from the ground up, and it needs experienced people to do it. For a mining professional, that is a rare thing: a place where your experience is scarce, valued and well paid.



The global majors are already on the ground.
The talent race has started



\$2.5T

In mineral wealth the Kingdom is racing to unlock, gold, copper, phosphate, rare earths and battery metals



200,000

Mining jobs the country aims to create by 2030



3rd pillar

Mining is now a national priority, alongside oil and petrochemicals

In a mature market you replace people who retire. Here, you build the thing. That is the difference between a job and a career-defining move.

THE MONEY

The Maths That Changes Everything

Saudi Arabia charges no personal income tax. None, regardless of your nationality. Layer the standard expat allowances on top, and the same headline salary puts dramatically more in your pocket, and lets you save what you couldn't at home.

AT HOME (TAXED)

\$130,000

 Salary

Income tax (~35%)	\$45,500
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Rent / mortgage	out of pocket
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School fees	out of pocket
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Medical cover	out of pocket
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Roughly in your pocket **~\$84k**

IN SAUDI (TAX-FREE)

\$130,000

 Salary

Income tax (~35%)	\$0
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Housing allowance (~25%)	+ provided
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School fees	+ supported
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Medical + flights home	+ included
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Plus end-of-service gratuity

~\$130k+

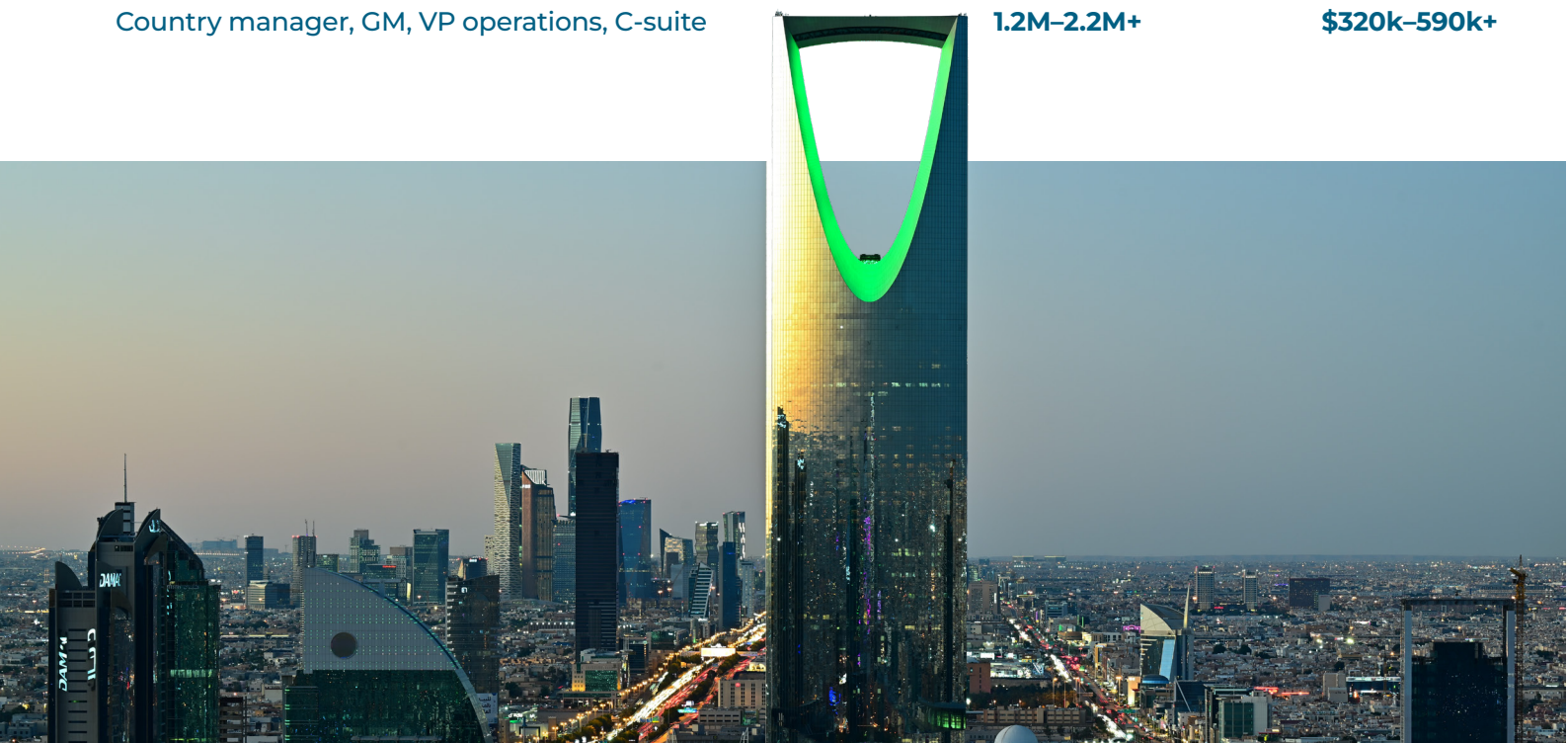
Same number on the contract. A different number in your bank account, and a bigger one in your savings.

THE NUMBERS

Indicative salary bands by role

Annual total-package ranges for internationally recruited mining professionals, tax-free.
Use them as a directional guide, not a quote.

ROLE	SAR / YEAR	USD / YEAR
Tier 1 Technical & field		
Graduate / field geologist, junior engineer	180k–300k	\$48k–80k
Mining engineer, exploration geologist, metallurgist	300k–520k	\$80k–139k
Geophysicist, drilling supervisor, mine surveyor	280k–480k	\$75k–128k
Tier 2 Senior technical & operations		
Senior / resource geologist, senior mining engineer	450k–720k	\$120k–192k
Process / plant engineer, mine planner, geotech	380k–640k	\$101k–171k
HSE manager, maintenance / reliability manager	420k–700k	\$112k–187k
Tier 3 Leadership		
Mine manager, plant manager, operations manager	700k–1.15M	\$187k–307k
Project director (development / EPC)	900k–1.45M	\$240k–387k
Country manager, GM, VP operations, C-suite	1.2M–2.2M+	\$320k–590k+



THE PACKAGE DECODED

What's actually in the offer

A Saudi mining package is rarely just a salary. The allowances are where the real value sits, and they are usually structured to be tax-free in the contract.



Tax-free base salary

No personal income tax on employment earnings, for any nationality. Your gross is, in effect, your net.



Housing

Typically a housing allowance of ~20–40% of base, or direct accommodation in a compound. Often the single biggest add-on.



Children's schooling

Support toward international-school tuition for dependents, a major cost covered that you would pay yourself at home.



Medical insurance

Private health cover for you and usually your family, included as standard in most professional packages.



Flights home

One or two annual round-trip tickets to your home country for you and dependents.



Transport

A transport allowance or company car, commonly SAR 1,500–3,000 a month for professional roles.



End-of-service gratuity

A legally-mandated payout on departure: half a month's basic pay per year for the first five years, then a full month per year after, a built in lump sum.



Real mobility

Since the 2021 labour reforms you can change employers and manage your own exit and reentry via the Qiwa and Absher platforms.

THE LIFESTYLE

It isn't the posting it used to be

If your picture of Saudi Arabia is a decade old, it's wrong. Vision 2030 has reshaped daily life, and the cost of it all sits well below London, Sydney or Toronto.



Entertainment, finally

Riyadh Season and Jeddah Season concerts and theme parks, cinemas in every major city, and global events from Formula 1 to world title boxing



Compound living

Purpose-built gated communities with pools, gyms, tennis courts, kids' clubs, social events and a relaxed, mixed, international feel.



The Red Sea on your doorstep

Luxury resorts, world-class coral diving and island trips, an outdoor life most expats never expected.



You'll save more

A family of four lives comfortably on roughly SAR 12,000–20,000 a month, competitive with Dubai, Doha and Muscat, and below most Western capitals.

FOR YOUR FAMILY

The questions your partner will ask

A move like this is a family decision. The honest answers are more reassuring than most people expect.



Schools

British, American, IB and other international curricula across Riyadh, Jeddah and Dammam, with tuition support commonly built into your package.



Your partner's life

Compound communities, social clubs and a fast-expanding calendar of mixed-gender public life make it far easier to build a circle quickly.



Safety

Low everyday crime and high-security compounds are consistently cited by expat families as a genuine quality-of-life advantage.



Healthcare

Modern private hospitals in the major cities, covered through the medical insurance included in your package.

Modest dress and respect for local customs are expected. In return, families consistently report a safer, more sociable and more affordable life than they left behind.



FOR CAREER

This accelerates you. It doesn't stall you.

The biggest fear about a frontier market is getting stuck. Saudi mining is the opposite: scarce experience, fast scaling and real mobility mean careers move quicker here than in saturated markets.



Scarcity works for you

There is very little local mining experience yet. Your skills are in genuine demand, which means leverage on role, scope and pay.



Build, don't maintain

Greenfield exploration, new plants and first-of kind projects give you scope and ownership that mature operations rarely offer.



Step up a level

Rapid scaling routinely lets people take on bigger titles and teams years earlier than they would at home.



You're not locked in

The 2021 Labor Reform lets expats change employers and handle exit and re-entry independently, the old sponsorship trap is gone.



Ten years from now, the people who helped build Saudi mining will be the ones the rest of the industry hires. That experience is being created right now.

THE MOVE

From Perth, Joburg, Toronto or Santiago to site

The relocation itself is more straightforward than most people assume, especially with a partner managing the visa and mobilisation for you.

01

The conversation

A confidential chat about your experience, what you're looking for, and the roles that fit, no CV blast, no obligation.

02

The match & offer

We line you up with the right operator or project and help you read the full package, base, allowances and the real take-home.

03

Visa & mobilisation

Work visa, Iqama (residence permit), medicals and documentation handled and tracked, so dates actually hold.

04

Landing & settling

Flights, housing, compound options, schooling and arrival logistics organised before you fly, for you and your family.

05

Someone in your corner

A point of contact on the ground once you're there, for the questions that come up in the first few months.

MYTH VS REALITY

Let's clear a few things up

The assumptions that stop people applying are mostly out of date. Here's the current picture.

THE MYTH

- ✗ It's a hardship posting with nothing to do.
- ✗ The money's good but you can't save it
- ✗ My family won't cope
- ✗ I'll be trapped with one employer

THE REALITY

- ✓ Concerts, cinemas, F1, the Red Sea and a fastgrowing social scene. Daily life now rivals Dubai.
- ✓ Tax-free pay plus housing and a lower cost of living than most Western cities means a higher savings rate.
- ✓ International schools, secure compounds and strong expat communities make family relocation well-trodde
- ✓ Since 2021, expats can change jobs and manage their own exit and re-entry through official platforms.

THE FIT

Is this your move?

If you recognise yourself in most of these, it's worth a conversation.

This move tends to suit you if...

- ☐ You have mining experience, technical, operational or leadership, and want it to count for more
- ☐ You're earning well at home but watching tax and cost of living eat most of it
- ☐ You want scope and ownership, not another seat in a mature, slow-moving operation
- ☐ You're open to a 2–4 year move that could reset your savings and your career trajectory
- ☐ You'd relocate solo or with family, given the right package and the right support

In demand right now

Geologists, mining & process engineers, metallurgists, mine planners, HSE leaders, plant and mine managers, and project directors.

From these markets

Australia, South Africa, Canada and Chile, the talent pools Saudi operators are actively recruiting from today.

The move others will wish they'd made.

Saudi mining is hiring now, while the sector is young and the leverage is yours. The professionals who move early will set the pay, pick the projects and build the track record everyone else chases later. We place mining talent into the Kingdom and handle everything from the offer to the airport, with someone in your corner once you land.

Have a confidential conversation about live roles

Tell us your discipline and what you'd want to make the move worth it. We'll tell you honestly whether the roles, the package and the timing line up, and what your next step looks like.

[Talk to our mining team](#)

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